

Chapter 56-2: 笔友 (Pen Pal)

The next day was overcast and rainy. Since there were no classes anyway, Ning Fuyi didn't leave her room for half the day. She hugged Ping'an¹ and curled up on the bed, reading through the cultivation manuals that Chu Qingqiu had previously written for her.

After noon passed, the pattering rain outside finally ceased. Ning Fuyi put down the booklet she had already memorized once and used her divine consciousness to look outside.

Since breaking through to the Clear Realm, her use of divine consciousness had become increasingly skillful. Although she still couldn't detect movements a hundred li away like high-cultivation cultivators, nor could she see too clearly, covering Cloud Ascension Mountain was no problem.

Though the rain had stopped outside, everything was still damp. The ground was full of puddles, and the roses by the roadside had been beaten down by the rain, their red and pink petals floating in the muddy water.

As she was watching, the transmission plaque at her waist suddenly vibrated. Ning Fuyi withdrew her divine consciousness and picked up the plaque, hearing Rong Jin's weak voice as if he had run a hundred li in one breath.

"Fuyi, come find me quickly! Emergency!"

Ning Fuyi immediately leaped from the bed, placed Ping'an (who had grown so fat it was impossible to tell head from tail) on the ground, and transformed her body into a stream of light, appearing outside Xuanliang Pavilion.

Rong Jin, who was holding dozens of bamboo scrolls in his arms, was startled by her sudden appearance and kept backing away. When he focused his eyes and saw clearly, he said in surprise: "Fuyi?"

"When did your cultivation advance so much?"

"I've been training diligently recently." Ning Fuyi laughed it off, looking down at the bamboo scrolls in his arms. "These are..."

"Don't even mention it. Now that Elder Jingshan is not here, I'm the only one responsible for food, clothing, housing, and daily life in the sect, and I still have to manage the remaining disciples' cultivation. I haven't closed my eyes these past few days!" The dark circles under Rong Jin's eyes had almost reached his chin. If not for his eyes still having some spirit, he would be a walking corpse.

He said this while handing over his sleeve: "There's a letter from Sect Leader Tang Wenshu delivered by divine bird inside, to be given to Elder Pingyao. I really can't spare the time, so please help me make this trip."

Ning Fuyi reached out and pulled out the thin letter. Before she could speak, Rong Jin had already rushed into Xuanliang Pavilion holding the bamboo scrolls, disappearing in the blink of an eye, leaving only his instructional words: "Elder Pingyao is at Cloud Deep Hall!"

Ning Fuyi stood there, helplessly shaking the letter.

Probably because of the rain, there were no disciples practicing at the entrance to Cloud Deep Hall. The water had washed the jade-white ground spotlessly clean, so clean that stepping on it was slippery.

Ning Fuyi held the letter and walked up the steps. Before entering, she heard arguing voices from inside. She stopped at the doorway, unsure whether she should interrupt.

The argument was between a man and a woman. The male voice was artificially gentle, while the female voice was full of vigor—clearly Mei Chengsì and Elder Pingyao.

"This venerable one believes there's no need to worry about this matter. Immortals and mortals are different; as long as mortal affairs don't involve demons, they have nothing to do with our immortal sect. Moreover, no one has petitioned us. Why should our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate wade into these muddy waters?"

"How does the Sect Leader know this matter doesn't involve demons? No one knows the reasons behind it now. If we don't quickly send people to investigate, what if the tragedy of Cangyun Kingdom² repeats itself!" Although Elder Pingyao's words were still respectful, she was clearly struggling to contain her anger.

"The sect no longer has manpower. What remains are just disciples without much cultivation. The empress matter is just a small affair—why should we interfere?" Mei Chengsì said with a smile.

"But..."

"Elder Pingyao." Mei Chengsì emphasized his tone. "This venerable one is the sect leader. This venerable one has the final say in this matter. No further discussion needed."

"This..."

"Enough." Mei Chengsì waved his hand dismissively. "This venerable one hasn't had time to taste the pastries sent from Dongyue. Let's not discuss this matter further."

With that, he swayed his sleeves and stepped outside, meeting eyes with Ning Fuyi who was waiting at the door. Those eyes hidden under thick eyebrows examined Ning Fuyi, and he stroked his beard before leading two protectors past her.

Ning Fuyi secretly spat at his retreating figure, then knocked on the door frame and stepped inside.

Elder Pingyao, dressed in dark purple robes, stood in the shadows. Her angular face was tightly drawn, clearly suppressing anger. She forcefully adjusted her hair crown before suppressing her fury.

"What is it?" She turned toward Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi didn't want to touch her bad mood, so she lowered her head and presented the item: "Elder, this is what Senior Brother Rong Jin asked me to deliver. He said it's a letter from Elder Tang Wenshu."

Elder Pingyao's tense mouth finally relaxed a bit. She extended her thin hand to accept it: "Alright, you may go."

Ning Fuyi was backing away to slip out when Elder Pingyao suddenly called her back: "Wait."

Ning Fuyi looked up suspiciously and found Elder Pingyao beckoning to her, lowering her voice: "Ning Fuyi, how long have you been back at the sect?"

"A few days." Ning Fuyi leaned back slightly.

"Do you know that Liu Wenzhu is currently in Qi Kingdom?" she asked again. "Do you know about Qi Kingdom's emperor's sudden personality change and debauchery?"

Ning Fuyi nodded.

"Good." Elder Pingyao put her hands behind her back, her expression still stern. "Wenzhu sent word at noon that the Qi Kingdom mission is very difficult. I'm considering sending more people to assist her. You and Wenzhu are close friends—would you be willing to go take a look?"

Ning Fuyi thought to herself that although Elder Pingyao seemed serious and upright, she was actually quite cunning inside. With words like these, how could she say she was unwilling?

Moreover, she was indeed worried about Liu Wenzhu, so she nodded again: "This disciple happens to be free."

"Good." Seeing her agreement, Elder Pingyao's expression relaxed somewhat. She patted Ning Fuyi's shoulder: "The matter is urgent. It would be best to depart today."

She then walked toward the door with her hands behind her back: "Remember not to let Sect Leader Mei know."

As soon as she finished speaking, she disappeared. Ning Fuyi straightened her shoulder that had been knocked askew, suddenly feeling like she was meeting Elder Pingyao for the first time.

Not knowing what had happened to Liu Wenzhu, she didn't delay. She returned to Zhuguan Pavilion to pack some clothes and personal items into her Thought Pearl, entrusted Ping'an to that pigtailed female disciple, and planned to go to Qi Kingdom alone.

However, Qi Kingdom was in the territory of the Xiangshan Liu clan, quite a distance from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Flying by sword would take most of a day, and she was worried about Liu Wenzhu, so she brazenly slipped into Jingshan Palace.

She knocked at Chu Qingqiu's door and said carefully: "Divine Venerable, could I borrow Bai Lin³ for use?"

The room was silent for a good while before Chu Qingqiu's cold voice came through: "What for?"

"I need to make a trip to Qi Mountain to find Liu Wenzhu." She answered truthfully.

After waiting for a while with no response, just as Ning Fuyi thought Chu Qingqiu was ignoring her and was preparing to fly by sword herself, the door suddenly creaked open. Bai Lin was thrown out with claws extended, landing heavily in Ning Fuyi's arms.

Ning Fuyi almost failed to catch it. She stepped back twice to steady herself, and when she looked up, a figure with skin like ice and bones like jade brushed past her.

"What is the Divine Venerable doing?" Ning Fuyi asked in surprise.

Chu Qingqiu, holding White Bone in her hand, had already gracefully descended to the ground floor: "I'll go with you."

Footnotes:

1. **平安 (Ping'an)** - Ning Fuyi's pet, whose name means "peace" or "safety."
2. **苍云国 (Cangyun Kingdom)** - The kingdom mentioned earlier where Qiu Yi was from, which was destroyed by demons.
3. **白麟 (Bai Lin)** - Chu Qingqiu's divine beast companion, a white qilin (Chinese unicorn).